

Psalms 75

Promotion from God

Promotion cometh neither from the east, nor from the west... but God is the judge

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Unto thee, O God, do we give thanks, unto thee do we give thanks: for that thy name is near thy wondrous works declare.*
- 2 *When I shall receive the congregation I will judge uprightly.*
- 3 *The earth and all the inhabitants thereof are dissolved: I bear up the pillars of it. Selah.*
- 4 *I said unto the fools, Deal not foolishly: and to the wicked, Lift not up the horn:*
- 5 *Lift not up your horn on high: speak not with a stiff neck.*
- 6 *For promotion cometh neither from the east, nor from the west, nor from the south.*
- 7 *But God is the judge: he putteth down one, and setteth up another.*
- 8 *For in the hand of the LORD there is a cup, and the wine is red; it is full of mixture; and he poureth out of the same: but the dregs thereof, all the wicked of the earth shall wring them out, and drink them.*
- 9 *But I will declare for ever; I will sing praises to the God of Jacob.*
- 10 *All the horns of the wicked also will I cut off; but the horns of the righteous shall be exalted.*

2 · CONTEXT

A short thanksgiving psalm that pivots on a single conviction: exaltation and demotion are ultimately God's business, not the result of human maneuvering. Henry reads it as a rebuke to ambition that schemes for advancement while ignoring the God who actually raises and lowers. MacArthur-style notes highlight the cup of judgment imagery, echoed later by the prophets, as a picture of God's precisely measured response to human arrogance.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

Thanks are given for God's wondrous, near works. God Himself speaks of judging uprightly when the appointed time comes, and declares that when the earth and its inhabitants seem to be dissolving, He is the one holding its pillars steady—stability rests in His hand, not in circumstances.

Verse 4-5

A direct word to the arrogant: stop dealing foolishly, stop lifting up your horn (a picture of self-exalting pride), stop speaking with an insolent, stiff neck. Boastfulness is confronted head-on rather than politely ignored.

Verse 6-10

The psalm's key line follows: promotion comes neither from east, west, nor south—only from God, who puts down one and raises up another. A cup of judgment, fully mixed, is poured out for the wicked to drink to its dregs, while the psalmist commits to declaring this forever and singing praise to the God of Jacob. The image closes with every proud horn cut off and the horns of the righteous exalted—reversal by God's own hand, not human striving.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Genuine advancement—of position, reputation, or influence—is God's prerogative to grant or withhold, not a prize won purely by ambition or self-promotion. Arrogance that assumes it controls its own rise will eventually meet the same God who alone determines who is lifted up and who is brought low.

Application for life today.

Examine where you are quietly relying on self-promotion, networking, or striving as though advancement were entirely in your hands, and bring that ambition under this psalm's correction. When you see others exalted unfairly or feel overlooked yourself, let verse 6–7 recalibrate your expectations toward God's timing rather than your own maneuvering. Practice declaring God's justice 'forever'—that is, choosing to trust His timing even before any visible reversal occurs.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where are you currently tempted to force your own 'promotion' rather than trust God's timing (vv. 6–7)?

2. How does picturing stability as resting in God's hand, not your circumstances (v. 3), change your response to instability right now?

3. What would it look like to actively resist a 'stiff neck' attitude (v. 5) in a specific relationship or situation?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).